

Light and dark

Tone—the relative lightness or darkness of colors—is the most important building block for all painting. It creates pattern and shape, movement and design. Color, depth, and focus are all diminished without good, clear use of tone. A painting in which all the

colors are of a similar tone looks dull because there are no high notes or low notes—nothing stands out. To create subtle paintings full of energy and interest, it is best to limit the colors you choose and to use neutrals to create a varied range and depth of tone.

LIMIT YOUR PALETTE

Working with a limited range of colors that are close together on the color wheel holds a painting together and gives it unity. The colors can be based around any one of the primary colors and will each contain a certain amount of that color. Including one complementary color in your selection will enable you to create a range of harmonious neutrals and semineutrals that also unify the painting. Using a very small amount of the pure complementary color in your painting will give emphasis to the composition and make the colors sparkle.



In the color wheel, all the colors are equal in tone, so no one color stands out.



Limited palette of yellow-green, green, blue-green, and complementary red.



Limited palette of blue-green, blue, blue-purple, and complementary orange.



Limited palette of blue-purple, purple, and red-purple, and complementary yellow.



SELECTING TONES

Using a simple range of close tones in your painting will help to hold all the different elements of your composition together. Most paintings only need a range of three close tones, accented by a few very dark tones and the white of the paper to create drama and focus. Make sure that you have identified all the tones in a scene before you decide where to simplify them. To help you see the tone of an object, compare it with the colors surrounding it. You may also find it useful to hold a piece of white paper next to the tone to see how light or dark it is when compared with white.